ENGLISH LAB · READING CORNER

Lantern Night

An old lantern. A lost tradition. A secret waiting to be told.



Core · B1

4 ESO · Seasons & Celebrations · LS2
Six chapters · one a week

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How to read this book

Read one chapter a week at home, with the Learning Path it goes with. Read it once for the story, then again more slowly.

The words in the box at the start help you. They are underlined in the story.

At the end of each chapter, circle one answer to each question. In class we talk about the chapter for ten minutes and see who guessed what happens next.

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CHAPTER 1

The lantern in the attic

Read it with Learning Path 0

WORDS TO HELP YOU

attic = *golfes*
lantern = *fanalet*
ink = *tinta*
shake = *tremolar*
dusty = *ple de pols*

Núria Puig arrived in Ashby, a small town in northern England, on Saturday 24 October. She was fifteen and spent the autumn term with the Green family. Josh Green, her exchange partner, met her at the station. They knew each other from online chats, but this was their first meeting in person.

"Welcome to Ashby," Josh said. "The best thing here is rain. The second best thing is more rain."

"Great. I brought one umbrella and a lot of hope."

Her new routine took some getting used to. She got up at seven, walked to school with Josh and had dinner with his family at six. In Catalonia, her family usually ate at nine. The clocks went back that weekend, and soon it got dark before five. Josh lived with his mum, Helen, his little sister, Amy, and his grandmother, Margaret Green, whom everyone called Gran. Gran was kind but quiet. She loved her garden and always made tea at four.

Every afternoon after school, Núria called her family to tell them about England. She liked Ashby, but she missed the warm evenings in Barcelona. Josh tried to make her laugh. "You can join my family for a second dinner at nine," he said. "My little sister is always hungry."

When Gran offered Núria a cup of tea, Núria asked about the garden. Gran told her the names of the flowers and showed her a few red and

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yellow autumn leaves.

For a moment, Ashby felt a little more like home. On Halloween Amy dressed up as a witch and Josh carved a pumpkin. At dinner Núria described the Castanyada. “In Catalonia, we roast chestnuts and sweet potatoes. We also eat panellets.”

“Can I dress up as a chestnut?” Amy asked.

“You can try,” Núria laughed.

Helen suggested making panellets the next day, so Josh and Núria went to the attic to find something for cooking panellets.

The room was dark, with boxes of old decorations and a broken lamp.

“This place is a museum,” Josh said. “A very dusty museum.”

Under the window, Núria found a red and gold paper lantern. It had a message written in black ink: “M. — Lantern Night, at the old bridge. I’ll wait for you. T.”

“What’s Lantern Night?” she asked.

“No idea. Maybe it’s a secret Halloween club.”

They carried the lantern downstairs. Gran drank her tea. When she saw it, she stopped smiling.

She read the message, and her hands began to shake. “Where did you find this?” she asked.

“In the attic,” Josh said.

“Who’s T?” Gran didn’t answer.

“Put it back, please,” she said quietly.

Then she left the room. For the first time since she arrived, Núria felt that the old house hid a story.

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THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

What makes Gran upset?

- (A) An old lantern with a message
- (B) A pumpkin costume
- (C) Núria's homework

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What do Josh and Núria find at the library?

- (A) An old phone
- (B) A poster for Lantern Night in 1974
- (C) A letter from Canada dated today

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CHAPTER 2

A poster from 1974

Read it with Learning Path 1

WORDS TO HELP YOU

gathered = *es van reunir*
harvest = *collita*
damaged = *malmès*
faded = *descolorit*

Gran didn't come down for breakfast the next morning. Josh and Núria were worried, but neither of them wanted to make her feel bad by asking questions. "Somebody else must know about Lantern Night," Núria said.

"Mrs Okafor," Josh replied. "She works at the library. She probably knows what everybody in Ashby ate for breakfast in 1974."

The library was in the community centre, close to the town square. Mrs Okafor took one look at the lantern and smiled.

"Lantern Night! Where did you find this beautiful thing?" Josh explained, and she led them to some old posters.

One read: "ASHBY LANTERN NIGHT — SATURDAY 16 NOVEMBER 1974. PARADE FROM THE TOWN SQUARE TO THE OLD BRIDGE. LIVE MUSIC. HOT FOOD. BRING YOUR LANTERN!"

"This used to be our biggest autumn celebration," Mrs Okafor said. "Families used to make lanterns at home. Then everyone gathered in the square and walked to the bridge. They lit candles and made a wish."

"Was it like Halloween?" Josh asked.

"Not exactly. It began as a harvest festival, long before the costumes and sweets we see today."

Núria remembered their talk at dinner. "At Diwali, families light diyas. There's a Lantern Festival in China too. And in Catalonia the

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Castanyada brings families together around autumn food. The customs are different, but the feeling is similar."

"Very well put," Mrs Okafor said. "Many celebrations are about light, family and the change of seasons."

Mrs Okafor showed them another photograph.

It was a family standing in the square with lanterns made at home. The children smiled and the parents wore winter jackets. "People used to bring food as well as lanterns," she explained. "There was music, and neighbours who didn't usually talk during the week got together for one evening."

Josh pointed at a tiny lantern in the photo. "That one looks like a potato."

"Maybe it is a potato," Núria said. They laughed, but the picture made the lost festival seem real.

"So why did Ashby stop?" Josh asked.

Mrs Okafor's smile faded. "In 1974 there was a terrible storm. The old bridge was damaged, so the parade was cancelled. After that, no one organised it again. The young man who used to lead the festival left town the following week."

"That sounds like a film," Josh said. "Like the ending of a film."

"What was his name?" Núria asked.

"Tom Barker. He moved to Canada." Núria held the lantern close and read its faded message once more: "M. — Lantern Night, at the old bridge. I'll wait for you. T."

"T," she said slowly. "T is for Tom."

Josh looked at her. "Then who's M?"

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THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

What did people do at Lantern Night?

(A) They held a parade to the old bridge

(B) They went on a school trip to London

(C) They played a football match

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

Who is M on the lantern?

(A) Mrs Okafor

(B) Amy

(C) Gran, whose name was Margaret Hall

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CHAPTER 3

Who is M?

Read it with Learning Paths 2 and 3

WORDS TO HELP YOU

forum = *fòrum*
claimed = *va afirmar*
evidence = *proves*
archive = *arxiu*
caption = *peu de foto*

That evening Josh and Núria sat at the kitchen table with a laptop and the old lantern. They wanted to find out who M was and what happened to Tom Barker.

"Let's check the sources carefully," Núria said. "Who wrote it? When? What evidence have we got?"

"You sound like Mrs Okafor," Josh said. "Good. She's usually right."

Their first result was a forum called Ashby Memories. A user claimed that Lantern Night ended because of a big argument between two families.

There was no date, no name and no source.

"That's a story, not evidence," Josh said.

Next, they found a social media page with an old photo of the bridge. It showed a parade, but nobody knew who took the picture or when.

"Interesting, maybe. But we can't trust it yet," Núria said.

Finally, they discovered the online archive of the Ashby Herald. An article dated 17 November 1974 had the journalist's name and described the storm.

Strong winds broke part of the old bridge, the council closed it, and Lantern Night was cancelled. Tom Barker, aged twenty-one, planned to leave for Canada the following week. Then Josh saw a photograph beside the article. A young woman held a red and gold lantern, just like

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the one on the table. Its caption read: “Margaret Hall, 19, who helps Tom Barker organise the festival.”

“Margaret Hall,” Josh said again. “Gran’s name is Margaret. And Hall was her surname before she married Grandad.”

“So M is your gran,” Núria said. “And Tom wrote the message. He wanted to meet her at the bridge.”

“But there was a storm, and the bridge was closed,” Josh added. “Maybe they never met again.”

“The article says the bridge was closed,” Josh said. “It doesn’t explain what happened between Tom and Gran.”

“Right,” Núria agreed.

“A good source helps us find facts. It doesn’t give us permission to make up someone’s feelings.” Josh read the caption again. “She looks happy in that photo.”

“Maybe she was,” Núria said.

“But we shouldn’t guess the whole story from one picture.” She suggested asking Gran only when she seemed ready.

Josh agreed and moved the laptop away from the lantern. Núria recorded the evidence in her notebook: author, date, newspaper and photo caption. She didn’t want to mix up a fact and a guess. For a while neither of them spoke. Then she looked at the lantern again. “We could bring Lantern Night back,” she said.

Josh almost let go of his cup. “What? This year?”

“Yes. We can ask the school to help, organise a workshop and invite the whole town. It was for everyone. Maybe it can be for everyone again.”

Josh smiled. “We have about six weeks. That’s not much time.”

“Then we’d better start.”

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THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

Which source gives the most reliable evidence?

(A) An anonymous forum

(B) A dated newspaper article with a journalist's name

(C) A photo without a date

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What permission will the group need?

(A) Permission to use the old bridge

(B) Permission to travel to Canada

(C) Permission to change schools

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CHAPTER 4

Plan the day

Read it with Learning Path 4

WORDS TO HELP YOU

timetable = *horari*
workshop = *taller*
council = *ajuntament*
draft = *esborrany*
permission = *permís*

On Monday Josh and Núria told their friends about the idea Priya and Callum. "We're going to bring back Lantern Night on Saturday 12 December," Núria said. "Any volunteers?"

Callum looked at her. "You're planning a whole festival in six weeks? I can't even plan my homework."

"That's why we've got Priya," Josh said.

Priya opened her laptop. "I'll make a timetable. But first we need to decide what people are really doing."

They drew up a list: book the school hall for a lantern workshop, put up posters, send invitations, plan food and music, and ask the council about the old bridge.

"I'll make the posters," Callum offered.

"My uncle has a band," Priya said. "I'm going to ask him to play."

"And I'll speak to Mr Davies, our head teacher, on Wednesday," Josh added.

"It will rain," Callum said. "It's northern England in December."

"Then we'll organise umbrellas too," Núria replied.

Mr Davies, who loved local history, agreed to let them use the school hall. They worked out the programme: a free workshop at four, food in the square at half past five, a parade at six, and music and wishes at seven. At the workshop, people are making their own lanterns; after

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that, everyone is walking together to the bridge. Priya typed each activity into the timetable. At lunch the next day, Priya checked which families wanted to help.

Some offered decorations, others could bring hot food, and a local shop offered paper for the lanterns. Callum made two different posters: one for school and another for the town square. They agreed that the event would be free and open to everybody, not only people whose families lived in Ashby for years.

“Good,” Núria said. “A tradition is much more interesting when new people can join it.”

One problem was still there.

The council looked after the old bridge, and nobody knew if the group could use it.

“We need a formal email,” Josh said.

“I’ll write it,” Núria answered. “I know the right words. And we must ask before we promise anything.”

That evening Callum sent a draft poster. It showed a dark blue sky full of lights and the words “ASHBY LANTERN NIGHT IS BACK!” Josh printed it and left it on the kitchen table. At dinner Gran noticed the poster.

She put on her glasses and read the date slowly. The family stopped talking as she looked from the poster to the teenagers. “Who told you about Tom?” she asked.

Josh and Núria exchanged a nervous look. They didn’t tell her his name before that moment.

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THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

What must they ask the council?

(A) Money for fireworks

(B) A new bus

(C) Permission to use the bridge

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What will Gran do after seeing the poster?

(A) Tell the teenagers her story

(B) Leave Ashby forever

(C) Stop the school project immediately

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CHAPTER 5

Gran's story

Read it with Learning Path 5

WORDS TO HELP YOU

upset = *disgustar*
lost touch = *van perdre el contacte*
retired = *jubilat*
permission = *permís*
attached = *va adjuntar*

The kitchen went quiet. Gran was still holding Callum's poster.

"We found your lantern," Núria began, "and an old article in the Ashby Herald. We're sorry if we've upset you."

Gran sat down slowly. "Tom Barker lived next door. We were very good friends. Every autumn we used to organise Lantern Night together. I was nineteen and he was twenty-one. At some point, friendship became something more."

Josh looked surprised. "Gran! You never told us."

"You never asked," she replied, with a small smile.

In 1974 Tom got a job in Canada and invited her to come with him. Margaret couldn't choose. She loved Ashby and her family, but she loved Tom too. He wrote a message on her lantern: he planned to wait for her at the bridge during the festival.

"I wanted to answer him there," Gran said. "Then the storm arrived. My father wouldn't let me go out in that weather. When I finally got to the bridge, it was closed and Tom was gone. He left for Canada the following week."

"Did you write to each other?" Núria asked.

"For a while. Then we lost touch. I met your grandad, and he made me very happy. But I kept the lantern. It made me think of a lovely celebration."

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Josh took her hand. “We’re trying to bring it back. Only if you’re happy about it.”

“I’d like that,” Gran said. “Very much.”

They talked about making sure the festival was right for Gran.

“We don’t have to tell everyone about Tom,” Núria said.

“People can enjoy the parade without knowing Gran’s family story.” Josh agreed.

Gran held the lantern again, and for the first time she didn’t ask them to hide it. She asked what time the workshop would start and if the town square would have hot soup. “Some things never change,” she said.

“People need food when it’s cold.” Everyone laughed, and the difficult talk became easier.

Later, Núria finished her formal email to Councillor Hughes. She explained the local tradition, the free workshop and the proposed parade on Saturday 12 December. She asked if the council could give permission to use the old bridge between six and eight in the evening. She ended: “I look forward to hearing from you. Kind regards, Núria Puig.” She read the email again and pressed send. At the same time, Josh searched online for Tom Barker in Canada. He found a seventy-three-year-old retired teacher in Toronto.

On his profile was a photo of a red and gold lantern. Josh felt nervous when he added Callum’s poster and began his message: “Hello. I think you knew my gran, Margaret Hall…”

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THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

Why did Margaret miss Tom at the bridge?

(A) She forgot the date

(B) The storm and her father kept her home, and the bridge closed

(C) Tom went to a different town

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What will Tom do after Josh contacts him?

(A) Delete the message

(B) Send a photo of Australia

(C) Come to Lantern Night

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CHAPTER 6

Lantern Night

Read it with the final product

WORDS TO HELP YOU

thick fog = *boira espessa*
repaired = *reparat*
set off = *es va posar en marxa*
reunion = *retrobament*
clapped = *van aplaudir*

Two answers arrived the following week. The council gave permission to use the old bridge, which was repaired in 2009. Josh received another message too. He read it several times, but kept the details to himself.

"Are you hiding something?" Núria asked.

"Maybe a small surprise," he replied.

On Saturday 12 December, Ashby woke up to thick fog. Callum stared at the sky. "I told you it would rain."

"That's fog," Priya said. "Different weather. Same Callum."

By the afternoon the sky was clear.

At four, the school hall was crowded with families making lanterns. Priya's uncle's band played, food tables gave people hot soup, and Núria's panellets disappeared from the table almost immediately. "I made sixty!" she said.

"Next year make six hundred," Josh suggested.

At half past five, everyone gathered in the town square. At six, the parade set off. The streets were bright with hundreds of colourful lights without fire. Gran walked at the front, holding her old lantern.

Josh stayed beside her, and Núria called her family in Catalonia to show them the celebration. "It's like the Castanyada with lights!" her little brother said.

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“And a lot more umbrellas,” Núria answered.

Priya checked her timetable one last time as they walked. Callum carried a box of extra lights for families who needed them, and the volunteers made sure nobody was left behind. The bridge was open and safe, just as the council said it would be.

Núria thought about the storm that stopped the event in 1974. Now the sky was clear and the old tradition had a second chance. Gran stopped to talk to a neighbour who remembered making lanterns as a child. “We should do this every year,” the neighbour said.

Gran smiled, but Josh looked very nervous. At the old bridge, Josh stopped walking. A tall older man stood on the other side, holding a red and gold lantern. Gran looked at him.

For a moment she couldn’t speak. “Hello, Margaret,” the man said. “I’m sorry I’m late.”

“Tom?” she said quietly.

Then she smiled. “Only fifty-two years late.” They both laughed.

The crowd clapped, but Josh gave them space to talk. He knew the meeting was for them. Later, people made wishes beside the bridge. Núria hoped the celebration would become a yearly tradition again. The following morning, the Ashby Herald printed a photograph of the parade and said there were plans for another Lantern Night next December.

“Are you coming back?” Josh asked Núria.

“Of course,” she said. “I’ll bring panellets. Lots of panellets.”

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THINK ABOUT IT

Circle one answer for each question.

1 · DID YOU UNDERSTAND?

Who appears at the old bridge?

- (A) Tom Barker with a lantern
- (B) A television presenter
- (C) The mayor in a witch costume

2 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT? GUESS!

What does the town plan to do next December?

- (A) Close the bridge again
- (B) Celebrate Lantern Night again
- (C) Cancel all winter festivals

✦ ✦ ✦

The end

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